

The Confidence Loop

How your protective response creates the “proof” that you’re failing.

THE IDEA

Low confidence isn’t just a feeling sitting quietly inside you. It changes what you do, and what you do changes the session. Then you look at the changed session and take it as evidence that your fear was right. That’s the loop, and it runs in five steps.

THE LOOP, WITH A REAL EXAMPLE

TRIGGER	You offer a reflection and the client goes quiet.
MEANING	You decide it means “I went too deep and I messed this up.”
PROTECTIVE MOVE	You overexplain and walk the reflection back.
CONSEQUENCE	The client has nowhere to go and withdraws further.
“PROOF”	You conclude “I can’t handle emotional depth,” and the loop is ready to run again.

WHY IT KEEPS HAPPENING

Protective moves work in the short term: speaking ends the awkward silence, avoiding the boundary avoids the guilt. Your brain records the relief and reaches for the same move faster next time. The relief is real; the cost is that your confidence never gets new evidence.

HOW TO INTERRUPT IT

Pick one loop you recognize, then one small experiment. “Next time a client goes quiet, I’ll wait three more seconds and ask what happened for them before I explain.” The alternative doesn’t need to be brilliant, only less automatic.

Your protective response can create the “proof” that keeps the fear alive.